

Gustavo Guallar

A time you helped a coworker improve their performance:

In my previous roles as a manager at Pinkerton Security and Equalizer Security, I consistently assisted team members in enhancing their performance when needed. However, I would like to share an incident from when I had no supervisory experience; my only assets were my youth and inexperience.

At that time, I was working for Gables Towing as a rollback driver. Four-wheel drive vehicles were not as common as they are today; almost all cars could be towed by wreckers. Rollback trucks were primarily used for luxury vehicles, such as Corvettes, Cadillacs, and Lincoln Continentals, and serious accidents where vehicles were not towable.

We had a contract with an insurance company to pick up all their vehicles and either take them to a collision center or their salvage yard, and between this new contract, the Police calls, and Triple-A requests for rollbacks, the company needed another driver.

The new driver was a young man like me. He could drive but had no experience as a wrecker or rollback operator. I was asked to train him within two weeks. Although this was a tight timeframe to properly train someone, it wasn't uncommon to encounter such situations at the time.

Due to his limited training, he began experiencing several issues right away. He struggled to load vehicles, took too long to complete calls, caused some damage, and frequently had to radio me for advice. Additionally, the stress from police calls was definitely a challenge for him.

All the shortcomings he had were expected of someone with two weeks' training, but other drivers and the dispatcher began mocking him, and even the boss started to publicly express dissatisfaction.

I have to admit that I was upset by the way he was being ridiculed, so I told the boss that I wanted to retrain him. The boss advised against it, but I insisted. Eventually, he said, "Fine, he is now your responsibility."

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Retraining him was going to have a financial impact on me because we worked on a 30% commission basis. Dedicating time to his calls and having him train on my calls would reduce my efficiency and, consequently, my income. However, I believed that since he was humble enough to accept all the criticism he received and was determined not to give up, he deserved my support.

We started working together, and I would only allow him to respond to easy calls by himself. After the first week, the new driver started improving steadily. I started giving him the most challenging tasks, sometimes making the work unnecessarily more difficult to build his confidence and experience and allowing him to respond to more complicated calls by himself.

After a little over a month, the owner of the company, accompanied by two of the most experienced wrecker drivers, responded to a police call of a very serious accident. The vehicles involved were extensively damaged, and the wreckers were unable to hook up two of the vehicles at the scene.

The new driver and I were dispatched to the scene. Upon arrival, I instructed the new driver to hook up to the blue car, as it was in the worst condition of the two vehicles. Immediately, the other drivers at the scene jumped in to assist him, but I stopped them.

I told them that when he needed help, they criticized and made fun of him. Now, he didn't need help; he was capable of doing the job.

That day, he earned respect and recognition, and I enjoyed witnessing it.

We remained friends for a long time. When I started working for Excalibur, I took him with me, and we drove the only two medium-duty trucks that Excalibur had at that time.